Before You Take Money

Set up payments, separate business money, keep simple records and write down your promises before your first customer pays you.

BUILDER | 60 MIN | PLAYBOOK: FIRST LAUNCH CHECKLIST | PLAYBOOK: THE SIMPLE OPERATIONS STACK

YOU WALK AWAY WITH
A tested way to get paid and refund, business money kept separate, a sales and expense log from day one, written promises and answers from a local professional.

USE IT
About two weeks before launch, in Build track week 3, alongside the Launch Countdown and before you share a payment link.

Getting paid is the easy part. Keeping it clean is the part most first-time founders skip. Work through this before anyone pays you. Most of it takes one afternoon.

This is a checklist, not legal, tax or financial advice. Rules depend on where you live and what you sell. When a question is about registration, permits or taxes, ask a local professional or your local small business office.

> Under 18? Read the 'If you're under 18' group before you open any account. It can change who opens them.

Payments

- [ ] Pick one processor for what you sell: Shopify for a store, a payment link for a service, a card reader in person.
- [ ] Check current fees and payout timing on the processor's own site.
- [ ] Connect the account your payouts will go to.
- [ ] Make a real payment with your own card.
- [ ] Refund that payment and confirm the refund went through.
- [ ] Turn on alerts so you know when money comes in.

> Many payment processors require the account holder to be an adult. Some let you start setup, but a parent or legal guardian must be added as the owner before you can take payments. Rules vary by processor and country, and they change.

If you're under 18

- [ ] Read each processor's current age rules before you sign up.
- [ ] Ask a parent or guardian to open the account, or be added as its owner, if the rules require it.
- [ ] Agree together on who can see the account and where payouts land.
- [ ] Ask the same age question about any bank account for business money.
- [ ] Ask a professional whether being under 18 changes anything else for you.
- [ ] Never fake your age or use someone else's details to get around the rules.

Keep business money separate

- [ ] Ask a professional which setup fits you, like a separate account or a business account.
- [ ] Send every business payment to that one place.
- [ ] Pay business costs from there, and never personal ones.
- [ ] Store your logins in a password manager.

Records from day one

- [ ] Make a simple sheet: date, what, sale or expense, amount, receipt link.
- [ ] Log every sale and every expense the day it happens, even small ones.
- [ ] Make one receipts folder and save a photo of every receipt.
- [ ] Check the sheet against your payment app once a week.

Bring these questions to an accountant, a lawyer or your local small business office. Don't guess the answers, and don't take them from a video.

Questions for a local professional

- [ ] Ask: do I need to register this business where I live?
- [ ] Ask: do I need to register my business name, and can I use it?
- [ ] Ask: does what I sell need a permit or license?
- [ ] Ask: do I need to collect sales tax, and on what?
- [ ] Ask: how is this income taxed for me, and how much should I set aside?
- [ ] Ask: which records should I keep, and for how long?
- [ ] Write down each answer, who gave it and the date.

Your promises

- [ ] Test your delivery time on a real order before you promise it.
- [ ] Write your refund or guarantee policy in two or three sentences.
- [ ] Put that policy where buyers see it before they pay.
- [ ] Write what happens after someone pays, step by step, starting with the confirmation message.
- [ ] Decide how you'll handle a refund request before the first one comes in.

> “Win their trust, win their wallet.”
>
> ELI

Customer info

- [ ] Collect only what you need to deliver: name, contact and order details.
- [ ] Keep customer info in one private place, like your Pipeline Tracker, and never share or sell it.
- [ ] Never store card numbers yourself. Your processor handles them.
- [ ] Ask before you add anyone to an email list.
- [ ] Get permission before you post a customer's photo or words.

Your setup, written down

Payment processor

And whose name the account is in

Where payouts go

The separate setup a professional suggested

Sales and expense log

Link to your sheet

Refund or guarantee policy

Two or three sentences

Professional I asked

Name, date and what they said

Next step

Money set up and tested? Open the Launch Countdown and lock in your launch date.

Make today day one.

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